

The train left at 3.30pm, reaching Howrah by 4.42pm. It is important to note that the special train was not taken to Raneegunge as the guests would have been unable to reach Calcutta that same evening, and the EIR did not run steamer services at night for safety reasons. A second, commercial train would later carry on towards Raneegunge.

A civil servant and, later, Commissioner of Patna, William Tayler noted the inaugural train run from Burdwan to Raneegunge with a “rather amusing anecdote”. It involved a carriage jam-packed with youth, huddled together, even as more were pushed in and the door closed. That’s when cries of protests went up with pleas to be allowed out. Apparently, a joyful bulldog somehow entered the carriage and merrily bit the exposed ankles of all passengers. “The scene was supremely ludicrous, the stifling crowd squeezed together as with a vice, the weak melancholy tone and expression of the victims, complacent grin of the guard and the evident enjoyment of the spectators, formed such an absurd scene that shouts of laughter greeted the sufferers instead of sympathy,” Tayler wrote in his autobiography *Thirty-eight Years in India: From Juganath to the Himalaya Mountains*.

The road to profit

This “fire chariot” had the desired impact as in the 15 weeks after the line opened, the number of passengers it carried was 179,404, with an average of up to 12,000 a week. Earnings rose to £900 a week. There was no doubt that this was going to be a profitable venture and an enterprise that would be impactful for centuries. The railways in Bengal turned out to be invaluable, not only as an efficient mode of communication and transportation, but also as the ace up the East India Company’s (EIC’s) sleeve during the Santhal Rebellion and later, the Revolt of 1857 (see [Revolts and the Railways](#)).